CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

IN THE COURT OF THE STAKEHOLDERS

Mistry's Tirade

In India, industrial boardroom battles may not be an everyday occurrence; yet, they are not uncommon either. Bombay House, which was largely cocooned from such turbulences, suddenly became the epicentre of a battle after Cyrus Mistry was replaced as chairman, Tata Sons. But it had not been meant to be like this. Ratan had not wanted his successor's departure to be rancorous.

Even after the board took the decision to replace Mistry, Ratan gave his successor the choice to continue as a director on it. At the meeting where Mistry was replaced, to a query if he would desire to continue on the Tata Sons board, Mistry had replied in the affirmative. In the case of his directorship in other companies, of which he had nine, Ratan was, however, non-committal.

By all indications, Ratan had not taken any decision on the issue of Mistry continuing as a director and chairman in the other companies, says R. Mukundan. He remarks that during the meeting Ratan held with the CEOs of Tata companies a day after Mistry was replaced, it was inferable from his pronouncements that he was open on the issue.

He recalls that in the meeting, Ajoy K. Misra, CEO of TGBL, asked Ratan what he should do as Mistry was the chairman of his company and its board was scheduled to meet soon. 'You deal with the meeting as you have been doing before. This [Mistry being replaced] should not bother you. You go and work as usual. I and Cyrus have not discussed anything about the next step,' Mukundan recalls Ratan as saying. Ratan also reiterated his